# MANCHEGO PDO



## THE BASICS

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| MAKE: | Hard |
| SUB MAKE: | Cheeses which acidify in the mould |
| POST-MAKE: | Wrapped, Rolled or Processed |
| SUB POST-MAKE: | Artificial (plastic coating, wax coat, matured in vacuum pack) |
| TYPICAL AGE PROFILE: | 30 days to two years |
| APPROXIMATE WEIGHT(S): | 400g to 4kg |
| GEOGRAPHICAL ORIGIN: | Spain |
| PROTECTED STATUS: | PDO – Queso Manchego must be made with sheep's milk in the La Mancha region of Spain, specifically Albacete, Ciudad Real, Cuenca and Toledo |
| SPECIES OF MILKING ANIMAL: | Sheep |
| BREED OF SHEEP: | Manchega breed |
| RAW/PASTEURISED MILK: | Examples of both depending on cheesemaker. Raw milk cheese must carry the term Artesano |
| VEGETARIAN/ANIMAL RENNET: | Typically animal rennet |
| COMMONLY ENCOUNTERED VARIATIONS: | N/A |

## THE STORY

Manchego can only be made in the La Mancha region of Spain made famous by Don Quioxte and his trusty sidekick Sancho Panza. They nibbled on the cheese when not tilting at windmills in Cervantes' famous story. Dry, arid and with temperatures up to 40°C during the summer, the harsh landscape is home to the hardy Manchega sheep breed, which graze the wild grasses and shrubs of the dehesa (wild meadows) and provide rich milk for cheese.

The curds for Manchego are scalded up to 40°C and the cheese is pressed, then dry-salted or brined. The zig-zag pattern on the rind was originally formed when the curd was placed in esparto baskets made from plaited grass to drain, but is now formed from an imprint on the moulds. The rinds may be sealed with a coating or rubbed with olive oil.

## THE CHARACTER

There are various styles of Manchego, depending on age. The tender, buttery fresco is typically just a few weeks old. Semicurado is aged for up to four months and has a firmer texture, although still mild flavour, while the three-to six-month curado is harder still

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with the beginnings of Manchego's trademark sweet dairy and nutty characteristics. This is fully pronounced in viejo (old) cheeses, which are aged for a year or more and have a long complex flavour.

### PERFECT PARTNERS:

Keep it all Spanish with Pedro Ximénez sherry – the wine's raisin notes marry with the mature cheese's sweet, meaty flavours.

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